POEM: EXPOSURE

Our brains ache, in the merciless iced east winds that knife us...
Wearied we keep awake because the night is silent...
Low drooping flares confuse our memory of the salient...
Worried by silence, sentries whisper, curious, nervous,
But nothing happens.

***Personification** of the weather described as 'merciless' and attacking them 'knife us' this is unexpected as we expect the fight to be between soldiers.*

***Sibilance** the hissing s sound capture the noise of wind, it sounds both lonely but also biting.*

Watching, we hear the mad gusts tugging on the wire.
Like twitching agonies of men among its brambles.
Northward incessantly, the flickering gunnery rumbles,
Far off, like a dull rumour of some other war.
What are we doing here?

*The man made weapons are likened through **metaphor** to natural objects, showing mans war is a cheap **imitation** of nature.*

***Rhetorical question** highlights the hopelessness of soldiers and war.*

The poignant misery of dawn begins to grow...
We only know war lasts, rain soaks, and clouds sag stormy.
Dawn massing in the east her melancholy army
Attacks once more in ranks on shivering ranks of gray,
But nothing happens.

***Contrast/oxymoron,** dawn is meant to be hopeful and positive, not miserable.*

*Now the rain is **personified**, nothing happens repeated to emphasise the helplessness of the soldiers who are beyond help.*

Sudden successive flights of bullets streak the silence.
Less deadly than the air that shudders black with snow,
With sidelong flowing flakes that flock, pause and renew,
We watch them wandering up and down the wind's nonchalance,
But nothing happens.

*Harsh **assonance** and **consonance** of s and t sounds link weather with gunfire and therefore conflict and pain.*

*Now the snow is described with **alliteration** to emphasise the f sounds and highlight the cold heavy blanketing of the weather. The wind's 'nonchalance' implies the weather sees the soldiers as beneath it and weak.*

Pale flakes with lingering stealth come feeling for our faces -
We cringe in holes, back on forgotten dreams, and stare, snow-dazed,
Deep into grassier ditches. So we drowse, sun-dozed,
Littered with blossoms trickling where the blackbird fusses.
Is it that we are dying?

*Man is **animalised**, likened to scared animals, rabbits in holes. Showing that before nature man is just an animal.*

***Rhetorical Question** shows the confusion of soldiers. Conditions are so bad they can no longer tell what is normal anymore.*

Slowly our ghosts drag home: glimpsing the sunk fires glozed
With crusted dark-red jewels; crickets jingle there;
For hours the innocent mice rejoice: the house is theirs;
Shutters and doors all closed: on us the doors are closed -
We turn back to our dying.

***Metaphor** frozen blood described as jewels, poet sees men's lives as valuable and ultimately wasted.*

Since we believe not otherwise can kind fires burn;
Now ever suns smile true on child, or field, or fruit.
For God's invincible spring our love is made afraid;
Therefore, not loath, we lie out here; therefore were born,
For love of God seems dying.

*So broken and hurt are the men that they feel abandoned and lose faith in God "our love is made afraid". **Contrasts/juxtaposes** the battlefield with garden of Eden. **Tone** is one of betrayal and despair.*

*Use of **scattered punctuation** slows the pace, we can imagine the soldier finally succumbing to exposure and dyeing.*

To-night, His frost will fasten on this mud and us,
Shrivelling many hands and puckering foreheads crisp.
The burying-party, picks and shovels in their shaking grasp,
Pause over half-known faces. All their eyes are ice,
But nothing happens.

***Metaphor** ice as in cold and dead but also dead and empty, without soul.*

***Repetition** final line emphasises the process doesn't end, the soldiers are frozen in time and hell.*

Wilfred Owen

An example of trench war, consider how exposed the soldiers are, imagine living there.

If you want to help your understanding you could:

-Look at some of Owen's other poems or the work of Sassoon, how do they talk of war?

-Do some research into trench conditions, see if you can find how many died from disease and cold.

Context:

Wilfred Owen was a soldier and officers in World War 1. He died before the end of the war but during his time he saw the full horror of conditions on the front line. He wrote a number of poems about this, published after the war with the help from fellow poet Siegfried Sassoon.

The war itself was often criticised because of a huge loss of life for very little gain. During the Somme over 60,000 British soldiers died in one day, and in all they only gained 6 miles by the end of the war. Owen's poems were often angry that the soldiers were in muddy dangerous trenches while the generals behind the lines were living in comfort. Owen's poems tried to show the truth of conditions to people back home. He was no against fighting, but was angry about the conditions soldiers had to live with in order to do so.

Wilfred Owen

Themes:

The poem itself is based on war and so links to conflict. The poem itself is about the weather and conditions of living in the trenches rather than any fighting. It is more a poem about the **conflict between man and nature**. This is extremely relevant because man has created machines that can launch explosive shells for miles and destroy the landscape, and yet, nature can still do more harm than any of it.

Trench conditions WWI

Structure: The poem uses a large amount of **ellipses**, **caesuras** and **repetition** to create an on-going sense of waiting and boredom. The poem is made of **eight stanzas** with a consistent use of a half line to end. This reinforces the sense of stasis or sameness throughout the poem that nothing is happening. There is use of **para-rhyme** showing words which appear to rhyme yet sound wrong when read to create the sense of unsettledness in the poem the soldiers are feeling. Owen also uses a huge amount of **onomatopoeia** and **alliteration** in the poem to emphasise the atmosphere and the sound of weather.

Man v Nature: Written about soldiers in a trench we expect to see a large amount of military language, however most of this is used to describe and **personify** the weather as if it were and army attacking them. The poem ends with the fear of tonight and the people who will lose lives and how none of this will change anything. Within the poem it is the weather that is represented as merciless and triumphant.

By the end of this you should know:

Higher Marks	Lower Marks
-The poem defies the convention of war and looks at the weather assaulting the soldiers, not another army. This is to highlight the unknown horrors of war to people at home.	*-The poem talks about soldiers suffering in bad weather.*
-The poet uses repetition and a consistent structure to create the static tone of the poem. The lack of change adds to the tone of despair.	*-The poet feels sadness and helplessness that these men are without hope and nothing is changing.*
-The alliteration is used to create a sense of atmosphere to the weather and to draw parallels to the violence of war and weather.	*-The poet uses a lot of alliteration and pauses in the poem to make it drag out and help us imagine the weather conditions.*

Space for your notes: